

PACKT EVENT SERIES • SESSION 4 OF 4

Power BI Acceleration

Explore, explain and extend a finance Power BI model — with Claude as your data analyst.

Lance Rubin — Model Citizn × Packt Publishing

Late July 2026 • Live cohort on Airmeeet • 2 hours

Session 4 of 4 — the finale



Sessions 1–3

- Claude set up safely for finance
- Excel: clean, build, reconcile
- Word & PPT: report and present
- A repeatable monthly pack



Today — Power BI

- Read a model: tables & relationships
- Understand DAX measures in English
- Draft new measures from a prompt
- Ask better questions of your data
- Keep finance judgement in charge

The Foundations You're Building On



Finance-Safe Prompting

Role + Task + Context + Format. The same framework applies when you prompt Claude about Power BI models.



The HACK Framework

Today we're firmly in Capability & Knowledge territory — using AI to do work you couldn't scale before.



Privacy & Governance

Your data boundaries still apply. Pro Plan, zero-retention, no training — the rules from Session 1 carry forward.



Systems Thinking

Models are systems. Power BI makes them visible — tables, relationships and measures are all connected.

Make it repeatable for the team as skills



Save skills

Keep the prompts that worked as skills — a Cleaner, a Checker, a Commentary writer.



Share a team library

Agree a common set so everyone gets consistent, reviewable output.



Reuse month on month

Same prompt, new file — the monthly close gets faster every cycle.



Keep the guardrails

De-identified data in, human sign-off out — every single time.

What You'll Be Able To Do After Today



- Read a star schema and explain it to a colleague
- Write DAX measures using plain English prompts
- Ask Claude to debug and explain existing measures
- Build a board-ready report from a data model
- Apply finance judgement to AI-generated analysis

Everything from Session 1 applies here — we're just adding a new surface.

The finance demo model we'll use



A star schema

- 1 fact table — monthly financials
- 5 dimensions — date, entity, account, department, scenario
- Actual, Budget & Forecast
- 3 years of synthetic AUD data
- All figures fictional, for training



What you can ask

- Revenue trend over time
- Actual vs Budget variance
- Margin by entity
- Opex by department
- Year-on-year growth

PART 1

Reading the Model



Before you analyse, understand the shape — tables, keys and relationships.

Fact and dimensions, the star schema



The fact table

Fact_Financials — one row per month, entity, account, department and scenario.



Dimensions describe it

Date, Entity, Account, Department, Scenario — the 'who, what, when'.



Keys join them

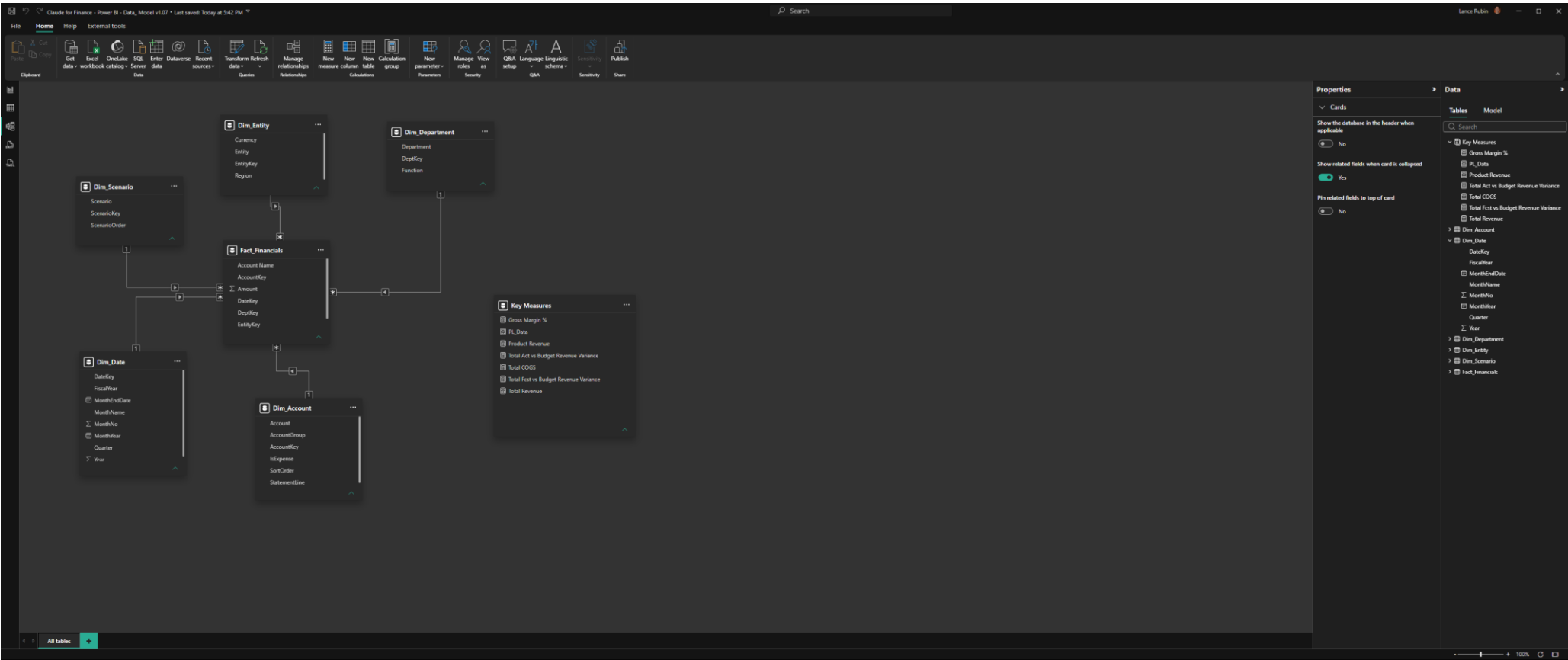
Each fact key links to one dimension — many-to-one, single direction.



Sign convention

Revenue is positive, costs negative — so Net Profit is just a SUM.

Fact and dimensions, the star schema



Let Claude explain the model to you

Map the model

"Here are my table and column names. Explain what each table is and how they relate."

Decode a measure

"Explain what this DAX measure does in plain English, step by step."

Spot the grain

"What is the grain of this fact table — one row represents what?"

Find the gaps

"What dimensions or measures am I missing for a standard board pack?"

Paste structure, not sensitive data — table and column names are enough for Claude to orient.

PART 2

DAX in Plain English



Read, explain and write measures — without memorising the syntax.

Plain English in — measure out

"Sum Amount where AccountGroup = Revenue."



```
Total Revenue =  
CALCULATE( SUM('Fact_Financials'[Amount]),  
  'Dim_Account'[AccountGroup] = "Revenue" )
```

"Actual revenue minus budget revenue."



```
Total Revenue Variance =  
CALCULATE( [Total Revenue],  
  'Dim_Scenario'[Scenario] = "Actual" )  
- CALCULATE( [Total Revenue],  
  'Dim_Scenario'[Scenario] = "Budget" )
```

"Sum Amount where AccountGroup = COGS."



```
Total COGS =  
CALCULATE(  
  SUM('Fact_Financials'[Amount]),  
  'Dim_Account'[AccountGroup] = "COGS"  
)
```

"(Revenue + COGS) / Revenue."



```
Gross Margin % =  
DIVIDE(  
  [Total Revenue] + [Total COGS],  
  [Total Revenue]  
)
```

Always test a new measure on a row you already know the answer to before you trust it.

Explain & debug what's already there



Decode a monster measure

Paste a nested CALCULATE and ask Claude to walk it through line by line.



Find why it's wrong

"This total looks too high — what in the filter context could cause that?"



Sense-check the logic

Ask whether the measure matches the label and the finance definition.



Document it

Get a plain-English note for the data dictionary, beside each measure.

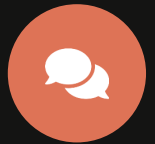
PART 3

Asking Better Questions



Turn a business question into the right analysis — and read the result critically.

Ask the data what matters



Ask in business terms

"Which entity drove the biggest unfavourable variance to budget last quarter, and which accounts explain it?"

- Name the measure you mean
- State the time period clearly
- Ask for the 'why', not just the 'what'
- Request a chart that fits the answer

Claude helps frame the analysis — Power BI runs the numbers and stays the source of truth.

Read the answer like a finance pro



Check the filter context

A wrong total is usually a filter problem — confirm what's included and excluded.



Does it tie out?

Cross-check the headline against a number you already know is right.



Question surprises

If a result looks off, it probably is — ask Claude what could explain it.



Own the conclusion

Claude suggests; you decide what the number means and what to do.

PART 4

From Model to Story



The full arc — explore the data, then report it like Sessions 2 and 3.

Power BI board pack (Actuals)

Home Page

Home

P&L Insights-Actual

P&L Insights-Budget

P&L Insights-Forecast

P&L Insights - Variance

P&L Insights Actual

Actual

Budget

Forecast

Entity

Account

AccountGroup

Department

Region

All

All

All

All

All

45.6%

Gross Margin %

(\$7M)

Act vs Budget Revenue

Actual Profit and Loss

AccountGroup	FY2024	FY2025	FY2026	FY2027	Total
Revenue					
Product Revenue	15,828,678	36,478,277	42,082,529	24,307,845	118,697,329
Services Revenue	7,900,655	18,269,321	21,023,537	12,316,142	59,509,655
COGS	(13,494,360)	(30,106,822)	(34,477,229)	(18,952,492)	(97,030,903)
Cost of Goods Sold	(13,494,360)	(30,106,822)	(34,477,229)	(18,952,492)	(97,030,903)
Operating Expenses					
Marketing & Advertising	(3,366,301)	(7,432,611)	(8,485,065)	(4,626,417)	(23,910,394)
Other Operating Expenses	(1,397,440)	(3,098,808)	(3,558,787)	(1,945,753)	(10,000,788)
Salaries & Wages	(11,669,020)	(25,638,005)	(29,512,728)	(16,223,335)	(83,043,088)
Software & Tools	(1,729,985)	(3,793,174)	(4,407,551)	(2,412,076)	(12,342,786)
Travel & Entertainment	(1,115,635)	(2,455,487)	(2,847,101)	(1,557,566)	(7,975,789)
Total					

Total Revenue by Entity

Americas

\$100M

\$50M

\$0M

\$80M

APAC

\$100M

\$50M

\$0M

\$41M

EMEA

\$100M

\$50M

\$0M

\$57M

Total Act vs Budget Revenue Variance by Entity

Americas

\$0M

(\$2M)

(\$4M)

(\$3.3M)

APAC

\$0M

(\$2M)

(\$4M)

(\$1.5M)

EMEA

\$0M

(\$2M)

(\$4M)

(\$2.4M)

Power BI board pack (Budget)

Home Page

Home

P&L Insights-Actual

P&L Insights-Budget

P&L Insights-Forecast

P&L Insights - Variance

P&L Insights Budget

ActualBudgetForecast

EntityAccountAccountGroupDepartmentRegion

AllAllAllAllAll

49.5%
Gross Margin %

(\$7M)
Act vs Budget Revenue

Budget Profit and Loss

AccountGroup	FY2024	FY2025	FY2026	FY2027	Total
Revenue					
Product Revenue	16,452,895	37,986,619	43,832,560	25,300,266	123,572,340
Services Revenue	8,226,447	18,993,315	21,916,281	12,650,134	61,786,177
COGS	(13,113,483)	(28,872,606)	(33,315,946)	(18,295,803)	(93,597,838)
Cost of Goods Sold	(13,113,483)	(28,872,606)	(33,315,946)	(18,295,803)	(93,597,838)
Operating Expenses					
Marketing & Advertising	(3,255,762)	(7,168,368)	(8,271,543)	(4,542,412)	(23,238,085)
Other Operating Expenses	(1,356,560)	(2,986,815)	(3,446,475)	(1,892,680)	(9,682,530)
Salaries & Wages	(11,304,729)	(24,890,182)	(28,720,643)	(15,772,246)	(80,687,800)
Software & Tools	(1,673,103)	(3,683,740)	(4,250,658)	(2,334,294)	(11,941,795)
Travel & Entertainment	(1,085,256)	(2,389,450)	(2,757,191)	(1,514,139)	(7,746,036)
Total					

Total Revenue by Entity

Americas

\$100M\$50M\$0M

\$83M

APAC

\$43M

EMEA

\$100M\$50M\$0M

\$59M

Total Act vs Budget Revenue Variance by Entity

Americas

\$0M(\$2M)\$4M

(\$3.3M)

APAC

(\$1.5M)

EMEA

\$0M(\$2M)\$4M

(\$2.4M)

Practical Claude AI for Finance Professionals • Session 4: Power BI Acceleration

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Power BI board pack (Forecast)

Home Page

Home

P&L Insights-Actual

P&L Insights-Budget

P&L Insights-Forecast

P&L Insights - Variance

P&L Insights Forecast

Actual

Budget

Forecast

Entity

Account

AccountGroup

Department

Region

All

All

All

All

All

45.8%

Gross Margin %

(\$1.2M)

FY27 Fcst vs Budget Revenue

Forecast Profit and Loss

AccountGroup	FY2024	FY2025	FY2026	FY2027	Total
Revenue					
Product Revenue		21,327,497		24,553,071	45,880,568
Services Revenue		10,617,499		12,231,562	22,849,061
COGS		(18,226,218)		(19,042,554)	(37,268,772)
Cost of Goods Sold		(18,226,218)		(19,042,554)	(37,268,772)
Operating Expenses					
Marketing & Advertising		(4,568,959)		(4,703,981)	(9,272,940)
Other Operating Expenses		(1,878,858)		(1,965,598)	(3,844,456)
Salaries & Wages		(15,635,234)		(16,438,190)	(32,073,424)
Software & Tools		(2,323,871)		(2,437,296)	(4,761,167)
Travel & Entertainment		(1,499,095)		(1,576,853)	(3,075,948)
Total					

Total Revenue by Entity

Americas

\$31M

APAC

\$16M

EMEA

\$22M

Total Act vs Budget Revenue Variance by Entity

Americas

(\$3.3M)

APAC

(\$1.5M)

EMEA

(\$2.4M)

Power BI board pack (Variance FY27)

Home Page

Home

P&L Insights-Actual

P&L Insights-Budget

P&L Insights-Forecast

P&L Insights - Variance

P&L Insights Variance

Entity

Account

AccountGroup

Department

Region

All

All

All

All

All

45.6%

Act Gross Margin %

49.5%

Budget Gross Margin %

-\$7.2M

Act vs Budget Revenue

45.8%

Fcst Gross Margin %

49.5%

Budget Gross Margin %

(\$1.2M)

FY27 Fcst vs Budget Revenue

Act vs Budget Revenue Variance

AccountGroup	FY2024	FY2025	FY2026	FY2027	Total
Revenue	(\$950,009)	(\$2,232,336)	(\$2,642,775)	(\$1,326,413)	(\$7,151,533)
Product Revenue	(\$624,217)	(\$1,508,342)	(\$1,750,031)	(\$992,421)	(\$4,875,011)
Services Revenue	(\$325,792)	(\$723,994)	(\$892,744)	(\$333,992)	(\$2,276,522)
Total	(\$950,009)	(\$2,232,336)	(\$2,642,775)	(\$1,326,413)	(\$7,151,533)

Forecast vs Budget Profit and Loss

AccountGroup	FY2027	Total
Revenue	(\$1,165,767.0)	(\$1,165,767.0)
Product Revenue	(\$747,195.0)	(\$747,195.0)
Services Revenue	(\$418,572.0)	(\$418,572.0)
Total	(\$1,165,767.0)	(\$1,165,767.0)

THE PROMPT PLAYBOOK

From Starting File to Board Pack



13 long-form prompts, 4 short-form prompts, and 10 Power BI steps — the complete recipe.

Starting file to board pack in 4 phases



Phase 1 • Excel: Build the Star Schema

Prompts 1–2: Create 5 dimension tables and reference sheets from the raw fact table.



Phase 2 • Power BI: Import and Model

Steps 1–4: Import 6 tables, verify column types, create 5 relationships, mark date table.



Phase 3 • Power BI: Create DAX Measures

Step 5: Build 14 DAX measures — revenue, margins, variance, scenario filters, time intelligence.



Phase 4 • Power BI: Build the Report

Steps 6–10: Home navigation + 4 P&L Insights pages (Actual, Budget, Forecast, Variance).

Build the star schema from scratch



Prompt 1 • Dimension Tables

Build 5 dimension tables (Dim_Date, Dim_Entity, Dim_Account, Dim_Department, Dim_Scenario) from the unique integer keys in Fact_Financials. Include Australian fiscal year, account groupings, and sort orders.



Prompt 2 • Relationships & DAX Reference

Document 5 star-schema relationships (Many-to-One, Single direction) and 14 DAX measures: Revenue, COGS, Gross Profit, Margins, Opex, Operating Profit, Net Profit, Scenario filters, Variance, YoY growth.

Import, transform, and model



Step 1 • Get Data from Excel

File › Get Data › Excel workbook. Select 6 tables: Fact_Financials + 5 Dim tables. Skip Read Me, Measures, Relationships.



Step 2 • Transform Data

Power Query: DateKey as Whole Number, Amount as Decimal, MonthEndDate as Date. Remove blanks. Close & Apply.



Step 3 • Create 5 Relationships

Model view: Many-to-One, Single direction. Fact_Financials → Dim_Date, Dim_Entity, Dim_Account, Dim_Department, Dim_Scenario.



Step 4 • Mark Date Table

Right-click Dim_Date › Mark as date table › MonthEndDate. Enables SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR and time intelligence DAX.

14 measures that power the report



Revenue Measures

Total Revenue, Total COGS (both CALCULATE + filter on AccountGroup), Gross Profit, Gross Margin %.



Profitability Measures

Total Opex (Operating Expenses filter), Operating Profit, Operating Margin %, Net Profit = SUM(Amount).



Scenario Measures

Actuals, Budget (scenario-filtered Net Profit), Variance to Budget (\$), Variance to Budget %.



Time Intelligence

Revenue PY (SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR), Revenue YoY %. These power the trend and variance analyses across fiscal years.

Five pages, one consistent layout



Home Page

Navigation buttons linking to P&L Insights — Actual, Budget, Forecast, Variance. Clean entry point.



P&L Insights — Actual, Budget, Forecast

Each page: Revenue by Entity bars, full P&L matrix (FY24–27), Gross Margin % KPI, slicers for Entity/Account/Dept/Region. Forecast shows FY26–27 only.



P&L Insights — Variance

Act vs Budget revenue variance matrix, 4 Gross Margin KPIs (Act 45.6%, Budget 49.5%, Fcst 45.8%), Fcst vs Budget FY27 comparison.

The quick-fire version



S1 • Excel Data Prep

Build 5 dimension tables + Relationships + Measures (DAX) reference sheets from Fact_Financials. Australian fiscal year.



S2 • Power BI Setup

Import 6 tables, create 5 star-schema relationships (Many-to-One, Single), mark Dim_Date as date table.



S3 • DAX Measures

Create 14 measures: Revenue, COGS, Gross Profit, Margins, Opex, Scenario filters, Variance, YoY growth.



S4 • Build the Report

5 pages: Home navigation, P&L Insights (Actual, Budget, Forecast), Variance with 4 margin KPI cards.

P&L Insights page anatomy



Revenue by Entity

Stacked bar chart — Americas, APAC, EMEA. Top-left. Shows total revenue by entity for the active scenario.



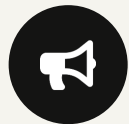
P&L Matrix

Matrix visual: AccountGroup rows (Revenue, COGS, OpEx breakdown), FY columns (FY2024–FY2027 + Total). Negatives in parentheses.



KPI Cards & Slicers

Gross Margin % card, Act vs Budget Revenue variance card.
Entity/Account/AccountGroup/Department/Region slicers.



Variance by Entity Chart

Bar chart: Act vs Budget Revenue Variance by Americas, APAC, EMEA. Positioned at bottom of each P&L page.

The finance story in one page



Revenue Variance Matrix

Act vs Budget by AccountGroup and FY. Total revenue variance: (\$7.2M). Product Revenue (\$4.9M), Services (\$2.3M).



Four Gross Margin KPI Cards

Side by side: Act Gross Margin 45.6%, Budget 49.5%, Fcst 45.8%, Budget 49.5%. Instant scenario comparison.



Forecast vs Budget P&L

FY2027 comparison — revenue variance (\$1.2M). Shows where the forecast diverges from the approved plan.



Cross-Check and Polish

Verify totals match Excel source. Check Forecast blanks for FY24–25. Apply theme, navigation, bookmarks, mobile layout.

What this report tells a CFO



Revenue underperformance

Actuals trail Budget by \$7.2M across all FYs. Product Revenue accounts for \$4.9M (68%) of the shortfall.



Margin compression

Gross Margin: Act 45.6% vs Budget 49.5% — a 3.9pp gap. Forecast (45.8%) tracks Actuals, not Budget.

Model to board pack, end to end



1 • Explore the model

Understand tables, measures and relationships with Claude's help.



2 • Pull the insight

Ask the business question; get variance, trend and driver analysis.



3 • Draft the narrative

Turn the numbers into a report — the Session 3 workflow.



4 • Present it

Board deck, branded and signed off — minutes, not days.

Everything you've built together



1 • Foundations

Claude set up safely for finance, with a prompting framework you trust.



2 • Excel workflows

Clean data, write formulas, build models and reconciliations.



3 • Word & PowerPoint

Reports and decks drafted from your numbers, in your style.



4 • Power BI

Read, explain and question a finance model with confidence.

Finance judgement, every session



Always

- De-identified data in
- One source of truth for numbers
- Test before you trust
- Human sign-off on every output
- Claude drafts, you decide

Never

- Paste confidential or named data
- Trust a number you can't trace
- Let Claude invent figures
- Ship without a human review
- Outsource the judgement call

Your next 30 days



Save your best prompts as a personal library



Agree a team standard for finance work



Pick one monthly task to automate first



Build a Cleaner, Checker and Writer prompt



Keep a de-identified sample dataset handy



Explain one inherited model or measure



Draft next month's report with Claude



Review every number before it goes out

THANK YOU

From spreadsheets to stories — finance, accelerated.

You've built a complete, finance-safe AI workflow — from clean data to a board-ready story.
The judgement stays yours; the grind is gone.

Let's keep the conversation going.

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